MONSOON LEDGER

Written by

Sample Writer

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Sample script for breakdown accuracy testing

FADE IN:

1 INT. ARJUN'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY 1

A narrow Mumbai kitchen. Steel utensils gleam on open shelves. Rain hammers the window grille.

DADI (80s), wrapped in a white cotton saree, sits on a low stool by the window shelling peas into a steel bowl. She does not look up.

ARJUN (45), shirt half-buttoned, gulps chai standing up. MEERA (40) packs a tiffin with brisk, practised movements.

MEERA
You didn't sleep again.

ARJUN
The accounts don't balance. Forty lakhs, Meera. Gone.

MEERA
(lowering her voice)
Is it Vikram?

ARJUN
Don't say his name in this house.

Dadi's hands pause over the bowl. Then continue.

KABIR (O.S.)
Papa! I'm going to be late!

Arjun grabs the tiffin, kisses Meera's forehead, and hurries out.

2 EXT. ARJUN'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS 2

A crumbling chawl courtyard flooded ankle-deep. KABIR (10), school bag over his head, waits under a dripping tin awning.

Across the courtyard, MRS. D'SOUZA (60s) waves from her balcony. Arjun waves back without breaking stride.

KABIR
Can we take the car today? Please?

ARJUN
Not today, beta. Today we walk.

They wade out through the gate, Kabir holding his father's sleeve.

3 INT. CITY HOSPITAL – ICU – NIGHT 3

Monitors beep in a dim, crowded ward. Every bed is taken.

DR. RAO (50s), tired eyes behind steel-rimmed glasses, studies a chart. NURSE LATA (30s) adjusts an IV drip.

Meera stands at the foot of a bed, clutching her dupatta, silent.

DR. RAO
The surgery has to happen this week. After that, I can promise nothing.

NURSE LATA
The deposit has to be paid first, Doctor. Accounts won't release the theatre.

DR. RAO
(to Meera, gently)
Has your husband arranged the money?

Meera can't answer. Dr. Rao exchanges a look with Lata.

NURSE LATA
Tell Arjun-ji to come to the billing counter tomorrow.

4 INT. CITY HOSPITAL – CORRIDOR – NIGHT 4

A long corridor lit by flickering tube lights. Families sleep on newspapers along the walls.

Arjun, soaked through, finds Meera sitting on a bench.

ARJUN
How much?

MEERA
Six lakhs. By Friday.

Dr. Rao walks past them, files under his arm. He nods at Arjun but doesn't stop.

ARJUN
I'll get it.

MEERA
From where? From him?

Arjun doesn't answer. He sits beside her and takes her hand.

5 EXT. CRAWFORD MARKET - DUSK 5

A huge crowd of shoppers jostles between fruit stalls under blue tarpaulins. Hawkers shout prices. Rain has eased to a drizzle.

THREE GOONS in matching black shirts shove through the crowd, clearing a path.

Behind them strolls VIKRAM (50), white kurta, gold chain, an umbrella held over him by one of the goons.

Arjun waits by a mango stall. He straightens as Vikram arrives.

GOON 1
Bhai is busy. Make it quick.

VIKRAM
Arjun. My old friend. You look terrible.

ARJUN
I need six lakhs. I'll pay it back with interest.

VIKRAM
(smiling)
You still owe me from last time. And the time before that.

Vikram picks up a mango, smells it, puts it back.

VIKRAM (CONT'D)
Bring me the ledger. Then we'll talk about money.

He walks away. The goons follow. The crowd closes behind them.

6 INT./EXT. ARJUN'S CAR - MOVING - NIGHT 6

An old Maruti crawls through flooded traffic. Wipers struggle against the rain.

Arjun drives, phone wedged against his shoulder.

ARJUN
He wants the ledger.

6 CONTINUED: 6

MEERA (V.O.)
(over phone)
Then give it to him. Kabir needs his mother more than you need your pride.

ARJUN
If I give it to him, he owns us forever.

MEERA (V.O.)
He already does.

The line goes dead. Arjun stares at the phone, then at the road.

7 INT. ARJUNS HOUSE - BEDROOM - NIGHT 7

Dark except for a bedside lamp. Arjun sits on the edge of the bed holding an old framed photograph: two boys on a riverbank, arms around each other's shoulders. Vikram and Arjun, decades ago.

He turns the frame over. Taped to the back is a small brass key.

He peels the key off and closes his fist around it.

DISSOLVE TO:

8 EXT. VILLAGE RIVERBANK - DAY (FLASHBACK) 8

Bright sun on a wide brown river. Buffaloes wallow in the shallows.

YOUNG ARJUN (10) and YOUNG VIKRAM (12) sit on a rock, feet in the water, sharing a stolen guava.

YOUNG VIKRAM
When we're big, we'll run the whole city. You keep the accounts. I'll keep the people in line.

YOUNG ARJUN
And we'll never lie to each other.

YOUNG VIKRAM
Never.

They spit in their palms and shake.

8A EXT. VILLAGE RIVERBANK - LATER 8A

The sun is lower. Young Arjun sits alone on the rock, scratching numbers into the stone with a pebble, adding and re-adding a column that will not balance.

9 OMITTED 9

INT. POLICE STATION - DAY

A cramped station house. Files tied with red string are stacked to the ceiling. A ceiling fan turns lazily.

INSPECTOR SHARMA (40s), crisp khaki, reads a newspaper with his boots on the desk. A CONSTABLE stands at the door, watching the rain.

Arjun sits across from Sharma, the brass key on the desk between them.

INSPECTOR SHARMA
A key. You came in this weather to show me a key.

ARJUN
It opens a locker at the cooperative bank. Inside is a ledger. Every payment Vikram ever made to anyone in this city.

Sharma folds the newspaper slowly.

SHARMA
Including to people in this building?

ARJUN
Including to you.

The Constable glances over his shoulder, then quickly looks away.

SHARMA
(quietly)
Go home, Arjun. Before you get hurt.

11 EXT. CITY HOSPITAL - DAWN 11

First grey light over the hospital gate. Rain has finally stopped. Street dogs sleep under parked ambulances.

Meera and Kabir sit on the hospital steps sharing a packet of glucose biscuits. Nurse Lata comes out, pulls off her

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11 CONTINUED: 11

mask, and sits two steps above them without a word.

KABIR
Is Papa coming?

MEERA
He promised.

Kabir leans against her shoulder.

12 HOSPITAL ROOFTOP - NIGHT 12

Water tanks and satellite dishes. The city glitters below, wet and endless.

Arjun stands near the edge holding a plastic-wrapped ledger. Vikram steps out of the stairwell door. Behind him, several of his men take up positions in the shadows.

VIKRAM
You went to the police. That was stupid, even for you.

ARJUN
You said never lie to each other. Remember?

VIKRAM
We were children.

ARJUN
I wasn't.

Arjun holds the ledger out over the edge. Vikram's men step forward. Vikram raises a hand and they stop.

VIKRAM
What do you want?

ARJUN
The hospital bill. Paid in full. And you never come near my family again.

A long beat. Vikram nods.

13 INT. ARJUN'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - LATER 13

The same kitchen, now quiet. The window is open; the rain has gone.

13 CONTINUED: 13

Meera washes cups at the sink. Kabir sleeps with his head on the table. Dadi is back on her stool by the window.

The door opens. Arjun enters, exhausted, empty-handed.

MEERA
Is it over?

Arjun looks at Dadi. For the first time, the old woman looks up.

DADI
Nothing is ever over, beta. Sit. Eat.

Arjun sits. Meera puts a plate in front of him.

14 EXT. ARJUN'S HOUSE - TERRACE - NIGHT 14

Arjun and Meera sit on the terrace parapet. Lines of washing flap in the breeze. Far away, thunder.

MEERA
Will he keep his word?

ARJUN
For a while.

MEERA
And after that?

ARJUN
After that, I keep the accounts.

She leans her head on his shoulder. The first drops of new rain begin to fall.

FADE OUT.

THE END